Jains in Kanchipuram (Tiruparuttikunram)

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Jainism flourished during the Pallava reign. In his writings, Chinese traveller Hiuen Tsang has mentioned about the presence of a large number of Buddhists and Jains during his visit to the Pallava country in 7th century A.D. Most of the Pallava rulers were Jains. Mahendravarman was a Jain initially. The two Jain temples in Kanchipuram are Trilokyanatha Jinaswamy Temple at Tiruparuttikunram, on the banks of the river Palar, and the Chandra Prabha temple dedicated to the Tirtankara named Chandraprabha. The architecture of these temples is in Pallava style, but it has deteriorated in due course of time. During the Vijayanagar rule (1387), Irugappa, a disciple of Jaina-muni Pushpasena; and a minister of Vijayanagar King Harihara II (1377-1404), expanded the Trilokyanatha Temple by adding the Sangeetha mandapa. The grand murals were added only at this time.



Jain Temple, Tiruparuttikunram

Mural paintings in the temples show scenes from the lives of Tirtankaras. Unfortunately the paintings of the Trilokyanatha temple at Tiruparuttikunram have been ruined by over-painting done during renovation. There is rich inscriptional evidence inside the second shrine, the Trikuda Basti, containing information on the development of the temple, and the contributions of various donors over the centuries.



Paintings on the walls of the Trilokyanatha Temple

In the Kanchipuram district, apart from Tiruparuttikunram, Jain vestiges have been found over the years in many villages across the state.

> The total population of Jains in Tamil Nadu is 83,359 or 0.12 per cent of the population as per the 2011 census.

Kazhugumalai Jain Rock-Cut Temple

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The 8th century Kazhugumalai temple in Kovilpatti taluk in Thoothukudi district marks the revival of Jainism in Tamil Nadu. This cave temple was built by King Parantaka Nedunjadaiyan of the Pandyan kingdom.

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